

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This letter to the editor appeared in a local newspaper:

Teachers must have the right to switch off

I am writing because I am concerned about the use of text messaging at schools in Hong Kong or to be precise the use of text messaging after school hours.

Many schools in Hong Kong now allow teachers and students to communicate with each other by text message. This is so much easier now for students, with the numerous instant messaging tools available on smartphones. It can significantly improve real-time communication when in the past a delay was inevitable.

Some schools even create WhatsApp groups for each class. These include the teacher, the students and critically they often include the parents.

As a result, many teachers nowadays are concerned about the number of text messages they get from parents after the school day has ended and they are back at home.

Many teachers feel they have to answer the questions that have been posed, often related to schoolwork. If they cannot give a swift reply then the students or their parents might blame them for being inefficient and not professionally-conscientious. If they do reply they are accused of being biased or favouring one particular student.

Students and parents need to appreciate that teachers have the right to enjoy their leisure time. In my opinion, teachers should be authorised to decline to reply to such questions after school hours if they want to.

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Your school principal is worried about the increase in the use of text messaging in your school. Your group is discussing this topic. You may want to talk about:

- why students and parents want to text teachers
- the advantages and disadvantages of students and teachers texting each other
- what schools can do to improve other means of communication between students and teachers
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you like to send text messages?
2. Do people in Hong Kong text too much?
3. Would you prefer to text your teachers or have face-to-face meetings?
4. Should students be able to text their teachers at any time?
5. Should schools set rules about texting?
6. What are the pros and cons of group chats?
7. When people take a long time to reply to text messages, is it rude?
8. How would you advise people to set boundaries between their personal and professional life?